

PROMISING RETURN PRACTICES

PRE-RETURN JORDAN

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Name of practice	Livelihoods, health, and legal access	
Dates	2014 - present	
Target group	Syrian Refugees	
Geographic Scope	Country	Jordan
	Regions	Asia
	Sub Region	Middle-East
Actor	Non-Governmental Organisations	
Return Stages	Pre-Return	
Challenge addressed	Legal and Procedural Alternatives to Return	
Principles referred (implicit or explicit)	Non-refoulement. Human rights-based approach Gender responsive Vulnerability & Child-centred perspective	

SUMMARY

The EU Madad Fund (EU Regional Trust Fund in Response to the Syrian Crisis), started in 2014, has assisted Syrian refugees and local communities by improving access to education, employment, healthcare, clean water, and protection services. It aims to create strong and cohesive communities, with a particular focus on children, youth, and women. The Madad Fund has also supported women's access to job training and helped establish women-led businesses, including beauty salons, restaurants, and retail shops, especially since many refugee households are headed by women. Then, the Jordan Compact (2016) allowed Syrian refugees to get work permits in specific sectors such as agriculture, construction, and manufacturing. While the Jordan Compact and Madad Fund incorporate gender-sensitive elements, their gender responsiveness remains uneven and highly dependent on complementary services such as childcare, transport, and legal support.

BENEFITS/IMPACTS AND SHORTCOMINGS

In terms of impact, work permits provide formal recognition and some benefits, including reduced risk of arrest, improved working conditions, and, in some cases, access to social security, though many refugees working informally see limited incentive to formalise due to administrative costs. Skills gained through vocational training, cash-for-work, and small business initiatives, alongside work experience and social networks, strengthen refugees' human capital, supporting potential sustainable return to Syria or durable local integration. However, evidence on long-term effects on actual return trajectories remains limited.

This policy measure/practice has also shortcomings. The Jordan Compact has fallen short in meeting its job creation goals. Although the plan aimed to create 200,000 jobs for Syrians, by 2018 only about 120,000 work permits had been issued, and just 42,000 permit-holders found formal employment. This disparity illustrates the gap between the policy's objectives and the realities of the labour market. Most work permits are concentrated in low-paying and seasonal sectors, particularly agriculture, and are often located far from refugee communities.

The geographic distance, along with challenges such as transportation and childcare, particularly affects women's ability to take advantage of these opportunities. Significant gaps also persist in legal protection and civil documentation. Many refugees—particularly those in informal settlements or with complex cases, such as unregistered marriages or children born in displacement—face barriers to obtaining or correcting official documents, creating inter-generational risks of statelessness and limiting both local integration and future return. Conditionalities, fines, and cross-border documentation requirements further hinder access, requiring ongoing advocacy to prevent the imposition of unaffordable penalties.

KEY LESSONS

Rights-based labour market access requires realistic sectoral planning. Granting work permits is a precondition for self-reliance, but without investment in sectors where the host country has a comparative advantage, employment targets may not be met.

Programme design must align with refugees' realities, particularly for women. Access barriers such as childcare, transport, safety concerns, and social norms limit participation, even where permits and training exist. In Za'atari, women hold only 20% of active work permits, underscoring the need for practical gender-sensitive measures.

Integrated services and legal support strengthen resilience but need explicit links to return. Multi-sectoral investments in education, health, livelihoods, and protection enhance human capital and community systems. However, connections to future return scenarios—portable qualifications, recognition of learning, and civil documentation—remain weak. Legal assistance is essential for a safe and dignified return.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Link labour-market access to genuine economic opportunities. Work permits should be tied to sectors with real comparative advantage and demand, supported by active labour-market policies, private-sector incentives, and local industrial strategies, rather than focusing solely on permit numbers.

Integrate legal aid and civil documentation into self-reliance and return programming. Civil documentation, residency regularisation, and legal counselling must be core components, with coordination between host- and origin-country authorities to ensure recognition of documents upon return.

REFERENCES

Norwegian Refugee Council (NRC). (2025). NRC Jordan fact sheet. NRC. from <https://www.nrc.no/jordan><https://www.nrc.no/jordan>

The Jordan Times. (2025). EU's Madad Fund channels €2.38b to support Syrian refugees, host communities. from <https://jordantimes.com/news/local/eus-madad-fund-channels-238b-euros-to-support-syrian-refugees-host-communities>